

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

THE SILENT FOOTSOLDIER

When the Bharat Jodo Yatra finally got over, the man most relieved in Congress was K.B. Byju. Though he doesn't occupy any post in the party, Byju has been the chief architect of the BJY's route and logistics. He was the main link between Rahul and other organisational units, external support infrastructure and state police forces. The 55-year-old former member of Rahul Gandhi's Special Protection Group became an integral part of the Congress leader's team after he became party general secretary in 2007 and has been overseeing his security ever since. Painfully media shy, Byju also enjoys the trust of the two other Gandhis—Sonia and Priyanka—because he never exceeds his brief. He had to deliver a mishap-free yatra, and he did.

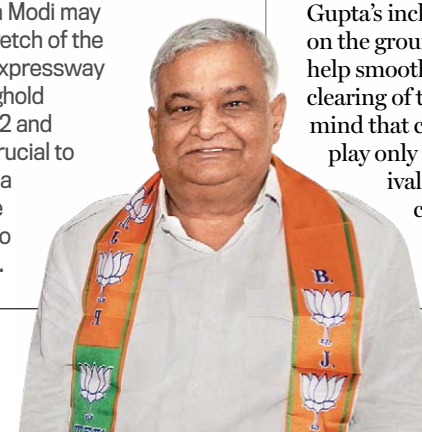
FAMILY BATTLE



Anupriya Patel, Union minister and Apna Dal (S) MP from Mirzapur, UP, may face a challenge from her own sister and Samajwadi Party (SP) MLA Pallavi Patel in the 2024 Lok Sabha election. SP sources say the party has no issue fielding Pallavi from Mirzapur, but chief Akhilesh Yadav will take a final call. Anupriya may face another challenge from within family—the Apna Dal (K) faction headed by her mother Krishna Patel, which has started preparing to field its own candidate. The Anupriya camp is in wait-and-watch mode, but it will certainly be an intriguing battle. In the 2022 assembly election, Pallavi beat none other than deputy CM Keshav Prasad Maurya.

Newfound Friend

Why has BJP Rajya Sabha MP **Kirodi Lal Meena** suddenly become the flavour of the season for his colleagues in Rajasthan? Deputy leader of Opposition Rajendra Rathore reached the site where Meena was staging a dharna against exam paper leaks, and ex-CM Vasundhara Raje also expressed support. State party president Satish Poonia can't stop singing his praises either. Word is, PM Narendra Modi may inaugurate a stretch of the Delhi-Mumbai expressway in Meena stronghold Dausa on Feb. 12 and Meena will be crucial to make the event a success. Hence the imperative to keep him happy.



PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR



Abiding Mystery

It has been over three years since NCP leader **Ajit Pawar** took oath as deputy chief minister in the shortlived government that he tried to form with Devendra Fadnavis and the BJP in a morning coup. It is something that intrigues seasoned politicians even today. NCP state unit chief Jayant Patil recently revived the debate when he suggested that it was perhaps a ploy by NCP supremo Sharad Pawar to avoid President's rule in the state. Ajit, on his part, has decided to stay mum on the subject. Silence, as they say, is golden.

BIG CAT DUTY

One lot of Namibian cheetahs safely ensconced in Kuno National Park, a high-level delegation is set to go to South Africa in February to get the next. Among its members, who are nominated by the Ministry of Environment, Forests and Climate Change (MoEFCC), will be Anish Gupta, a customs and central excise officer who was also part of the earlier team. Son-in-law of top MoEFCC honcho C.P. Goyal, who is the Director General of Forests, Gupta's inclusion came on the grounds that it will help smoothen the customs clearing of the animals. Never mind that customs come into play only at the port of arrival. What next? A customs officer to accompany every import to India?

Kaushik Deka with Anand Choudhary and Dhaval Kulkarni